evocative excursion. Medieval structures—the ramparts of a fort and a few Brahminical temples—still stand, likely built by the Reddi kings of Kondavidu in the fifteenth century, falling successively to the Gajapati rulers of Orissa and Krishnadevaraya of Vijayanagar. All visitors and employees leave in the evening and, at night, only two guards remain on the island.

Two Buddhist monasteries, a temple, and the city's famous amphitheatre were transplanted to the lake's eastern bank at Anupu, a few kilometres south from Vijayapuri South. I take an autorickshaw there one morning. The transplanted ruins include the monastery said to be associated with Nagarjuna. There are no other visitors; the quiet serenity of the place is only punctuated by birdsong. I sit in the empty stands of the amphitheatre and try to conjure up the bustle of the time.

It strikes me that history, as an account of our ancestors' lives and times, is necessarily based on material remains—monuments, sculptures, texts, other artefacts—mostly products of organized urban life. But while such a history reveals much about the kind of species we are, it only does so partially. The lives of our ancestors were far more varied than what their material remains indicate. For instance, at the edges of Vijayapuri and beyond were other groups that left no material remains at all—the Lambadis and Chenchus of the day who couldn't have cared less about Buddhism or Brahminism, preferring animistic folk deities and mother goddesses like Lajja Gauri instead—and who made up much of the subcontinent's population at the time. In the hinterland, these groups also often provided the labour and the food surpluses that funded Vijayapuri and its forms of creative life. We could as well say that history belongs to those whose creative works survive and vibrate in the minds of later historians.

On my final afternoon, I return to the site museum on Nagarjunakonda Island. I again pore over its exquisite sculptures, artefacts and archaeological data on the ancient city, though many of the best pieces are in museums elsewhere and in private collections. This museum too, like many other ASI museums, prohibits photography of works that have no copyright claims and were excavated with public money. Why? 'Orders from above,' they say, 'Apply for a permit in Delhi.' Unlike my previous visit, however, this time I manage to persuade the curator-in-charge to make an exception for my writing project.